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AI SUMMIT

INDIA'S AI MOMENT

THE INDIA AI IMPACT SUMMIT SIGNALLED THAT THE GLOBAL AI CONVERSATION'S CENTRE OF GRAVITY IS SHIFTING TO THE GLOBAL SOUTH

BY ARUN PADMANABHAN

FOR MOST OF the short history of artificial intelligence (AI) summits, the conversation has happened elsewhere. Bletchley Park in the UK, Seoul in South Korea, and Paris, France. The countries that build the most powerful AI models set the agenda, and everyone else showed up to respond.

In mid-February, for the first time, the Global South got to run the meeting.

The India AI Impact Summit, held from February 16 to 21 at the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, was more than just a change of venue. India came in with a different set of questions entirely, not just who controls the technology, but who it actually reaches.

The week ended with 88 countries signing a declaration, hundreds of billions of dollars in investment pledges and launch of India's first homegrown AI models. It ended with a robot dog scandal, a political protest inside the expo hall, and a few conspicuously empty chairs. That combination, serious ambition, real results, and unavoidable chaos, may be the most